



Sanjeev Keskar with wife Sangita

Asked if he was happy with the frequent transfers, Keskar replies that the best of his life lessons have come through these transfers and frequent changes in cities and schools. "Changing cities every three years really helped me in building new friends. Actually, these frequent transfers helped me cultivate a habit of networking and building relationships in the shortest possible time," recalls Keskar.

It is evident from the experience Keskar gained in the industry that he is one of the best communicators present in the vertical of the electronics industry today. Keskar refers to himself as an average student when it comes to scoring grades but is proud of the fact that he was, and continues to be, a contributor to social causes, and also to all his employers he worked for. He has represented his school and college in badminton and dramas during various social activities.

Keskar was looking forward to joining an engineering college after passing out from the school in 1982. But as fate would have it, he missed securing an engineering seat by a couple of marks, and there were not many private engineering colleges offering seats at that time. "All my friends made it to

engineering colleges. I was very nervous at that time as I was very confident that I would make it to an engineering college. I was clueless as to what to do next," recalls Keskar.

Priceless 700-rupee salary

Fate played a big role in helping Keskar on how he would be known in the electronics industry one day. He joined a diploma course in electronics at Maratha Mandal Polytechnic in Belgaum. "It was a three-year diploma and I completed it sincerely. But then came a time when I had to decide what to do next. I had the diploma in my hands, and I was not sure what to do next," notes Keskar.

His father was once again transferred to Pune and Keskar decided to move to Pune in 1985 with the family. Left with two choices - either to join second year in a full-time engineering college or to start a career, Keskar chose the latter. He saw an advertisement from a company named SAJ Froude. This company was hiring for the post of trainee engineers for their plant located in Pune.

Keskar applied for the same and began his career in the automotive testing equipment domain. He was offered

700 rupees as monthly take-home salary by the company. The best part working with that company, as Keskar explains, was that it was a very small setup. SAJ Froude at that time had a team strength of less than 100 individuals. "They rotated me into new departments every year. I got experience of working in production, testing, sales, marketing, and R&D departments. I spent more than six years with that company," shares Keskar.

It was a time when the amount of money he was earning didn't matter much to him. As Keskar explains, the experience and joy he found in that job was 'priceless.' "Frankly, I was enjoying work so much that I never thought of money as an objective. I was very happy," says Keskar with a big smile.

The teenage love and questions

While Keskar was enjoying his first job, there was a critical development taking place in his personal life. He got engaged to his teenage love Sangita, who was doing her MBBS at Aurangabad Medical College. He started looking for ways to pursue his engineering degree once again.

Keskar came to know about an evening part-time college that was offering engineering degrees to diploma holders. "It was a three-year engineering course spread over four years part-time for diploma holders. I joined the Cusrow Wadia Institute of Technology in 1987 while working at SAJ Froude," he says.

"Frankly, the intent was to get the engineering degree so that I could marry a doctor," recalls Keskar. He says the sole purpose of getting that degree was to be able to marry the love of his life. In the process not only he managed to get the degree and marry Sangita, he also found how helpful the knowledge was, which helped him to get jobs with MNCs later.

Average engineer, good cook

The person who has headed India Electronics and Semiconductors Association as chairman and has been country manager for America based organisations like National Semiconductor, AMD, and Freescale Semiconductor does not shy away from admitting that he is a better sales,